

The seating chart survival guide

Seating is the last job and the one that causes the most arguments. Here is the order to do it in, the rules that prevent trouble, and what to do about the people who make it hard.

DO IT IN THIS ORDER

1. **Wait for RSVPs.** Seating before the replies are in means doing it twice. Set your RSVP deadline four to six weeks out and chase by phone, not email.
2. **Fix the head table first.** Couple, then wedding party or immediate family — whichever you have chosen. Everything else arranges itself around this.
3. **Place the parents and grandparents.** Near the front, near each other only if that is genuinely a good idea, and close enough to see the speeches.
4. **Seat the big obvious blocks.** University friends, work friends, one side's cousins. Groups who already know each other are the easy 70%.
5. **Then the difficult ones.** Divorced parents, exes, the uncle with opinions. Doing these last means you can see exactly what space is left.
6. **Fill the gaps with connectors.** Every table needs at least one warm, chatty person who will talk to anyone. Spread them deliberately.

TABLE MATHS

TABLE	COMFORTABLE	MAXIMUM	NOTES
60" round	8	10	The standard. 10 is tight with big centrepieces
72" round	10	12	Better for conversation across the table
6ft banquet	6	8	Three per side, or four at a push
8ft banquet	8	10	Add the ends if space allows
Long feasting row	1 per 24"	1 per 22"	Measure the room before committing

THE RULES THAT PREVENT TROUBLE

- ☐ **Never seat two people who need managing at the same table**
If they must both come, opposite corners of the room and different sightlines.
- ☐ **Do not create a "leftovers" table**
Everyone can tell. Break the odd ones up across friendlier tables instead.
- ☐ **Keep older guests away from the speakers**
Not near the band, not next to the DJ rig.
- ☐ **Children together, but within sight of parents**
A kids table works beautifully until someone cries.
- ☐ **Put single friends with people, not with each other**
Nobody enjoys the singles table. Everyone notices it.
- ☐ **Check the sightlines**
Every guest should be able to see the ceremony of the speeches without turning fully around.
- ☐ **Plated dinner? You need place cards**
Servers need to know who ordered the fish.

- ☐ Assigned tables are usually enough
Assigned seats double the work for a small gain.

WHEN IT CHANGES AT THE LAST MINUTE

It will. Someone cancels the week of, someone brings a plus-one you did not plan for, and a table of eight becomes a table of six. Keep one table deliberately under-filled as your shock absorber, tell your venue the final numbers as late as they will allow, and do not laminate anything until the day before.

Using this with the HavenKept Wedding Planner: the **Seating Chart** section holds your tables and seats, drag-and-drop or tap-to-seat, with **Keep Apart Rules** that flag a clash as you make it. Guests flow in from the **Guest List** with their RSVPs and meal choices already attached, and the chart prints straight from the page.